

Some people think that philosophy is of no relevance to everyday concerns.

I hope that our class has disabused you of this notion. However, in this last class, I would like to turn the tools of philosophical analysis on two questions of great current concern.

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

Was the College Football Playoff committee's decision to exclude Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

Logically that there are four exclusive and exhaustive possibilities.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

Here is an argument against the first possibility.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not rely on absurd principles in making its decision.
2. The committee relied on absurd principles in making its decision.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best cars, or whatever.

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course depend on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one general kind of principle which one might use, which I will call a **magic touching rule**.

A magic touching rule is a rule which says that when two of the ranked items are 'touching' — i.e., adjacent in the rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this is the magic part — to see whether the two touching items in the ranking should have their spots flipped.

Magic touching rule

If two teams in the ranking are touching and played head to head and the lower ranked team defeated the higher ranked team then the teams' rankings are flipped.

The committee employs a rule of this kind.

It is easy to argue that magic touching rules are, in general, dumb. Either the extra condition (in this case the head to head result) is relevant to the ranking or it is not. If it is, it should be incorporated into the original ranking, in which case the flip is 'double counting' the relevance of the extra condition. If it is not relevant, it should also not be relevant in the special case of touching.

Further absurdities follow from the fact that the extra condition (winning a head to head matchup) is not a transitive relation.

Suppose that we have the following results: Team A beat Team B, Team B beat Team C, and Team C beat Team A.

Suppose now that we arrive at the following initial rankings:

Here is a second argument against the view that the decision
was competent and honest.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not inconsistently apply its own principles.
2. The committee inconsistently applied its own principles.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

I conclude that the committee's decision was not both competent and honest. So three possibilities remain.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

We can argue against the first as follows:

1. If the committee's decision was competent and corrupt, then the committee did not rely on obviously absurd principles and did not obviously inconsistently apply its own principles.
 2. The committee relied on obviously absurd principles in making its decision and obviously inconsistently applied its own principles.
-

C. The committee's decision was not competent and corrupt. (1,2)

If the committee
were competent, and
corrupt, we would
not find obvious
evidence of this; and
yet we do. So, if
they are corrupt,
they are not
competently so.

would like to turn the topic of philosophical analysis into questions of great

hope that our class has disabled you of this notion. However, in this last class, I



current concern.

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.



1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not rely on absurd principles in making its decision.
2. The committee relied on absurd principles in making its decision.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It

remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a

the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams

general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank

cars, or whatever.

general kind of principle which one might use, which will

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings

call it magic touch nothing rule.

of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course

dependent on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one

in the rankings should have their spots flipped.

rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this

the ranked items are 'touching' i.e., adjacent in the

is the magic part — to see whether the two touching items

A magical thinking rule is a rule which says that when two of

Magic touching rule

If two teams in the ranking are touching and played head to head and the lower ranked team defeated the higher ranked team then the teams' rankings are flipped.

It is easy to argue that magic touching rules, in general,

head result) is relevant to the ranking or it is not. If it is, it

as the flip is 'double counting' the relevance of the extra

should be incorporated into the original ranking, in which

dumb. Either the extra condition (in this case the head to

condition. If it is not relevant, it should also not be relevant

in the special case of touching.

transitive relation.

condition (winning a head to head matchup) is not a

Furtherabunditiesfollowthefactthatthe

Team B, Team Beat Team C, and Team Beat Team A.

Support that we have the following results: Team A beat

was competent and honest.

Here is a second argument against the view that the decision

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not inconsistently apply its own principles.
2. The committee inconsistently applied its own principles.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

conclude that the committee's decision was not both competent

and honest. So three possibilities remain.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.



1. If the committee's decision was competent and

corrupt.(1,2)



obviously inconsistently apply it to

principles in making it so clear and obviously

The committee's decision was not competent and



2. The committee relied on biased

obviously absurd principles and did not

inconsistently applied its principles.

corrupt, then the committee did not rely on

not finished

competently so.

for the community

corrupt, we would

yet we do. So, if

they are corrupt,

were competent, and

evidence of this; and

they are not

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.